

Nebraska - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-35 underlying quality with a sturdy bowl baseline and 8-win upside, but not a stable top-25 profile because high-leverage personnel changed and the schedule is top-10 difficult.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked, zero votes · SP+ No. 33
Returning production	69% (No. 4) overall · Off. 69% (No. 12) · Def. 69% (No. 7)
Primer power rating	+9.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.2 wins · likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Strong aggregate continuity, but more change at high-leverage spots than the 69% headline suggests.
Confidence	Medium

2026 identity: OC Dana Holgorsen turns to QB Anthony Colandrea and a returning pass-catching core while replacing star RB Emmett Johnson. New DC Rob Aurich installs a 4-2-5 around a reshaped front and secondary.

Bottom line: Nebraska's metrics are stronger than its unranked status, but improvement beyond 7-6 requires QB Anthony Colandrea, the new RB rotation and DC Rob Aurich's defense to hold up against a top-10 schedule.

Beats expectations if: QB Anthony Colandrea preserves the offense's efficiency, RB Isaiah Mozee replaces enough production, and DC Rob Aurich quickly improves havoc and explosive prevention.

Disappoints if: QB/RB turnover lowers efficiency, the defense misses LB Javin Wright, DB DeShon Singleton and DB Ceyair Wright, and the midseason gauntlet compounds the transition.

Five things to remember

- 1 Returning production:** Returning production is 69% overall (No. 4), 69% offense (No. 12) and 69% defense (No. 7) - elite continuity in aggregate, not at every high-leverage position.
- 2 ★ QB Anthony Colandrea:** QB Anthony Colandrea is the current projected starting QB and carries Maxwell recognition, replacing 2025 starter QB Dylan Raiola, who transferred to Oregon.
- 3 NFL departures:** RB Emmett Johnson's 1,451-yard, All-America/Big Ten RB of the Year season is gone to the NFL; RB Isaiah Mozee is the current lead-back front-runner.
- 4 ? Defensive availability:** Rob Aurich is a new external DC installing a 4-2-5; exact defensive game-day play-calling remains unresolved.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SOS is No. 10, including Indiana, at Oregon, Washington and at Illinois in a four-game midseason run plus Ohio State and at Iowa late.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	7-6 (4-5 Big Ten)	● Average / bowl-level
Scoring	28.7 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	370.5 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	145.9 YPG · 4.2 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	7.72 YPA · 23 TD / 7 INT	● Very good
Third downs	45.7%	● Very good
Scoring defense	24.6 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	329.5 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	175.4 YPG · 4.8 YPC	● Below average
Pass defense	154.1 YPG · 6.38 YPA · 9 TD allowed	● Very good

The offense was ordinary by scoring/yardage (No.59 scoring, No.82 total, No.80 rushing) but efficient through the air and on money downs (pass efficiency No.25, third downs No.27). The defense was excellent in total/pass yardage (No.30 total, pass efficiency defense No.27) but weak against the run (No.100).

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+2.84 · No. 46	● Good / above average
Off. EPA/play	+0.062 · No. 44	● Good / above average
Off. success rate	48.2% · No. 17	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	11.5% · No. 89	● Below average
Havoc allowed	12.3% · No. 20	● Very good
Opp.-adjusted defense	+1.42 · No. 53	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.002 · No. 63	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	40.7% · No. 54	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	13.1% · No. 103	● Below average
Havoc created	13.7% · No. 107	● Poor

Advanced-stat read: Nebraska's offense was efficient and protected itself but lacked explosiveness. The defense's strong yardage numbers overstated an average EPA/success profile with poor havoc and explosive prevention, making DC Rob Aurich's transition a major variable.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Matt Rhule - returning	● ↔ Program continuity stabilizes a roster changing at several star positions.
OC / offensive play-caller	Dana Holgorsen - returning	● ↔ Play-calling continuity helps buffer a new QB and lead back.
DC	◆ Rob Aurich - new external hire	● ↔ New 4-2-5 targets a low-havoc defense; first-year transition and exact game-day caller remain uncertainties.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Anthony Colandrea	-	● ↔ Projected QB1 with Maxwell recognition, but still replacing an established starter.
◆ OL Paul Mubenga	-	● ↔ Likely left guard who helps replace veteran OL losses.
◆ OL Brendan Black	-	● ↔ Right-guard candidate who adds needed interior depth.
◆ WR Kwazi Gilmer	-	● ↔ In the first WR group after WR Dane Key's departure.

Out	To	Loss
QB Dylan Raiola	Oregon	● ↓ The 2025 starter leaves, increasing uncertainty at QB.
RB Emmett Johnson	NFL (Kansas City), Round 5, No. 161	● ↓ The 1,451-yard All-America/Big Ten RB of the Year leaves the offense's largest production hole.
WR Dane Key	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Material 2025 WR production leaves.
OL Henry Lutovsky	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Meaningful veteran OL experience leaves.
OL Jason Maciejczak	Wyoming	● ↔ Twelve-game OL experience departs despite C Justin Evans projecting at center.

Offense net: ● ↔ **Similar**, but replacing QB Dylan Raiola and RB Emmett Johnson lowers the floor despite strong supporting continuity.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Owen Chambliss	-	● ↑ Projected starter with Butkus recognition in the new defense.
◆ DB Dwayne McDougale III	-	● ↔ Expected safety adds experience to a rebuilt secondary.
◆ DL Jahsear Whittington	-	● ↔ Interior rotation depth without a guaranteed major role.

Out	To	Loss
LB Javin Wright	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Team leader in tackles/TFL/sacks and a major defensive loss.
DB DeShon Singleton	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Thirty career starts plus team-leading PBU/INT production depart.
DB Ceyair Wright	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ All-Big Ten HM experience leaves the secondary.
DL Keona Davis	Miami	● ↓ Twelve-start lineman and line tackle leader departs.
EDGE Dasan McCullough	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Seven-start edge contributor leaves for the NFL.
S Malcolm Hartzog	Arizona	● ↔ Veteran DB depth departs after an injury-limited 2025.

Defense net: ● ↔ **Similar but volatile**; No. 7 returning production is offset by a new coordinator and multiple veteran departures.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	OC Dana Holgorsen offense built around QB Anthony Colandrea and a deep pass-catching group.	Strong 2025 success rate/havoc avoidance plus returning skill continuity.	Limited 2025 explosiveness and the loss of QB Dylan Raiola and RB Emmett Johnson.
Defense	DC Rob Aurich 4-2-5 built around speed and physicality.	High aggregate returning production and several projected major-role athletes.	Poor 2025 havoc/explosive prevention plus a new coordinator and veteran departures.
Special teams	Less settled after key return/special-teams departures.	No specific specialist weakness dominates the preseason view.	Return roles lose meaningful experience.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B–	● ↔	Medium	QB Anthony Colandrea is the projected starter with Maxwell recognition, but replaces QB Dylan Raiola.
RB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	RB Isaiah Mozee leads the projection after 1,451-yard RB Emmett Johnson departs.
WR	● B–	● ↔	Medium	WR Jacory Barney Jr. leads a solid group, but WR Dane Key’s experience is gone.
TE	● B–	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Luke Lindenmeyer is a projected starter with Mackey recognition.
OL	● B–	● ↔	Medium	C Justin Evans anchors a replenished line, but RT remains open after veteran turnover.
DL/Edge	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	A credible projected front replaces DL Keona Davis, EDGE Dasan McCullough and other veterans.
LB	● B	● ↔	Medium	LB Owen Chambliss and LB Vincent Shavers Jr. help offset the major LB Javin Wright loss.
Secondary	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	Transfers provide a new core, but multiple experienced DBs depart and CB2 remains open.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Key return/special-teams contributors depart without a clear recognition-level replacement.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium	HC Matt Rhule and OC Dana Holgorsen return; DC Rob Aurich installs a new system.
Overall	● B	● ↔	Medium	Top-35 quality and strong aggregate continuity, capped by high-leverage turnover and a top-10 schedule.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Anthony Colandrea	QB	● Projected Power Four starter / key swing player	Maxwell	The biggest variable in preserving 2025 offensive efficiency.
Jacory Barney Jr.	WR	● High-value returning playmaker	Paul Hornung	The clearest returning perimeter bridge for a new QB.
Isaiah Mozee	RB	● Unproven lead-back front-runner	-	First in the projection for RB Emmett Johnson’s vacated role.
Luke Lindenmeyer	TE	● Solid/high-upside conference starter	John Mackey	Stable projected starter around QB Anthony Colandrea.
Justin Evans	C	● Interior-line anchor	Rimington	The clearest stabilizer on a reworked OL.
Owen Chambliss	LB	● High-end transfer starter candidate	Butkus	Key replacement for LB Javin Wright’s lost production.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Williams Nwaneri	DL	● High-upside major-role defensive lineman	-	The new 4-2-5 needs front disruption after No. 107 havoc in 2025.
Dwayne McDougale III	DB	● Projected starting safety transfer	-	Important addition to a secondary replacing veteran departures.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Very hard; three favorable home nonconference games precede a punishing Big Ten slate.
Difficulty	● 9/10 · Very hard · SP+ SOS No. 10
Hardest stretch	Indiana → at Oregon → bye → Washington → at Illinois
Swing games	at Michigan State, Maryland, Washington, at Illinois, at Rutgers
Advantage	Three home nonconference games give the new QB, RB and defense time to establish roles.
Expected	6.2 wins · likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	No. 33 SP+ and elite returning production can make Nebraska better than its unranked label, but the favorable opening can create a misleading breakout signal before the top-10 schedule arrives; evaluate the team more by the Big Ten stretch than a fast start.
Back them when	Priced near average against teams that cannot force explosiveness, especially if QB Anthony Colandrea preserves 2025 efficiency.
Fade/pass when	Facing elite offenses before DC Rob Aurich's defense proves it can create havoc and prevent explosives.
Key monitor	QB Anthony Colandrea, RB order, RT winner, interior DL/CB2 competitions, exact defensive game-day caller
Week 1 baseline	Nebraska -23.5 vs. Ohio · rating-only baseline; +9.5 minus -11.8 plus 2.0 home field = 23.3, rounded to -23.5. Compare with the live market. Live market: Nebraska -24.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Nebraska combines top-35 model quality with elite aggregate returning production, but the continuity headline hides major change at QB, RB and several defensive leadership spots. QB Anthony Colandrea and DC Rob Aurich are the two biggest transition variables.

A sturdy bowl baseline remains, yet SP+ SOS No. 10 limits the upside of an otherwise encouraging roster. Six wins is the likeliest result; eight becomes plausible if the offense stays efficient and the new defense fixes its havoc/explosive-play problems.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [camp / roles](#) · [scheme](#) · [departures](#)

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